

Detective Fiction

Edgar Allan Poe, 'The Murders in the Rue Morgue' (1841), 'The Mystery of Marie Rogêt' (1842-3), 'The Purloined Letter' (1844).

Arthur Conan Doyle, *Adventures of SH* (1892), *A Study in Scarlet* (1887), *The Sign of Four* (1890), *The Memoirs of SH* (1894), *The Hound of the Baskervilles* (1902), *The Return of SH* (1905).

1. 'As a rule, the literary masterpiece does not enter any genre save perhaps its own; but the masterpiece of popular literature is precisely the book which best fits its genre. Detective fiction has its norms; to 'develop' them is also to disappoint them: to 'improve upon' detective fiction is to write 'literature,' not detective fiction. The whodunit par excellence is not the one which transgresses the rules of the genre, but the one which conforms to them' (Tzvetan Todorov, 'The Typology of Detective Fiction', in *The Poetics of Prose*, 1971)

2. 'Detective fiction is radically anti-novelistic: the aim of the narration is no longer the character's development into autonomy, or a change from the initial situation [...] On the contrary: detective fiction's objective is to *return to the beginning* [...] There is no 'voyage': only a long *wait*. In this sense, detective fiction is anti-literary [...] reading is no longer investment, choice, experience and intellectual effort: it is waste, error [...] it is only *distance* and *delay* with regard to the revealed *solution*' (Franco Moretti, 'Clues', in *Signs Taken for Wonders*, 1983)

3. "Here's a book for you to read till they come to fetch you. Good night!" [...] He turned over the leaves carelessly at first, but, lighting on a passage which attracted his attention, soon became intent upon the volume. It was a history of the lives and trials of great criminals, and the pages were soiled and thumbed with use. Here, he read of dreadful crimes that make the blood run cold [...] The terrible descriptions were so real and vivid, that the sallow pages seemed to turn red with gore, and the words upon them to be sounded

in his ears as if they were whispered in hollow murmurs by the spirits of the dead. In a paroxysm of fear the boy closed the book and thrust it from him. Then, falling upon his knees, he prayed Heaven to spare him from such deeds, and rather to will that he should die at once, than be reserved for crimes so fearful and appalling' (Charles Dickens, 'Wherein Oliver is Delivered Over to Mr William Sikes', *Oliver Twist*, 1837-9)

--Newgate Calendar; Newgate Novels (e.g. *Jack Sheppard 1839-40* by William Harrison Ainsworth); the murder of Lord Russell by Benjamin Courvoisier

--Dickens's 1850s essays about detectives in *Household Words*: 'A Detective Police Party', 'On Duty With Inspector Field', etc.

4. 'It was not merely that Holmes changed his costume. His expression, his manner, his very soul seemed to vary with every fresh part that he assumed. The stage lost a fine actor, even as science lost an acute reasoner, when he became a specialist in crime' ('A Scandal in Bohemia'); 'as he spoke he picked up the steel poker, and with a sudden effort straightened it out again' ('Speckled Band'); 'Ah, you're one that has wasted your gifts, you have! You might have aimed high, if you had joined the fancy [i.e., prize-fighting]' (*The Sign of Four*, Ch.5)

5. 'It is the agent of social justice who is the original and poetic figure' (GK Chesterton, 'A Defence of Detective Stories', 1901)

6. 'I believe in hard work, and not in sitting by the fire spinning fine theories' (Lestrade in 'Noble Bachelor')

7. 'To the man who loves art for its own sake [...] it is frequently in its least important and lowliest manifestations that the keenest pleasure is to be derived. It is pleasant to me to observe, Watson, that you have so far grasped this truth that in these little records of our cases which you have been good enough to draw up, and, I am bound to say, occasionally to embellish, you have given prominence not so much to the many *causes célèbres* and sensational trials in which I have figured, but rather to those incidents which may have been trivial in themselves, but which have given room for those

faculties of deduction and of logical synthesis which I have made my special province' (**'Copper Beeches'**)

8. '...Holmes, who loathed every form of society with his whole Bohemian soul, remained in our lodgings in Baker Street, buried among his old books, and alternating from week to week between cocaine and ambition, the drowsiness of the drug, and the fierce energy of his own keen nature' (**'A Scandal in Bohemia'**); 'I found Sherlock Holmes alone, however, half asleep, with his long, thin form curled up in the recesses of his armchair' (**'A Case of Identity'**); 'It saved me from ennui,' he answered, yawning. 'Alas, I already feel it closing in upon me! My life is spent in one long effort to escape from the commonplaces of existence. These little problems help me to do so.' (**The Red-Headed League**); 'Stand at the window here. Was ever such a dreary, dismal, unprofitable world?' (*Sign of Four*, Ch.1)

9. 'Boredom was not (*is* not) the same as ennui, more closely related to acedia [in e.g. Aquinas]. Ennui implies a judgement of the universe; boredom, a response to the immediate. Ennui belongs to those with a sense of sublime potential, those who feel themselves superior to their environment [...] No sensation, no stimulation, no activity arouses the victim of ennui, who proudly? despairingly? attests the permanence of his cheerlessness [...] If only because it seems more dignified, many people would rather suffer ennui than boredom, despite its presumably greater misery.' (**Patricia Meyer Spacks, Boredom: The Literary History of a State of Mind**, Ch.1, p.12)

10. 'brutal ferocity of such deeds [...] a *grotesquerie* in horror absolutely alien from humanity' (**'Rue Morgue'**)

11. 'we should bear in mind that, in general, it is the object of our newspapers rather to create a sensation – to make a point – than to further the cause of

truth' (**'Marie Rogêt'**); 'I read nothing except for the criminal news and the agony column [of the newspapers]' (**'Noble Bachelor'**)

12. 'Loveday Brooke, at this period of her career, was a little over thirty years of age, and could be best described in a series of negations. She was not tall, she was not short; she was not dark, she was not fair; she was neither handsome nor ugly. Her features were altogether nondescript; her one noticeable trait was a habit she had, when absorbed in thought, of dropping her eyelids over her eyes till only a line of eyeball showed, and she appeared to be looking out at the world through a slit, instead of through a window. Her dress was invariably black, and was almost Quaker-like in its neat primness. Some five or six years previously, by a jerk of Fortune's wheel, Loveday had been thrown upon the world penniless and all but friendless. Marketable accomplishments she had found she had none, so she had forthwith defied convention, and had chosen for herself a career that had cut her off sharply from her former associates and her position in society. For five or six years she drudged away patiently in the lower walks of her profession; then chance, or, to speak more precisely, an intricate criminal case, threw her in the way of the experienced head of the flourishing detective agency in Lynch Court. He quickly enough found out the stuff she was made of, and threw her in the way of better-class work—work, indeed, that brought increase of pay and of reputation alike to him and to Loveday. Ebenezer Dyer was not, as a rule, given to enthusiasm; but he would at times wax eloquent over Miss Brooke's qualifications for the profession she had chosen. "Too much of a lady, do you say?" he would say to anyone who chanced to call in question those qualifications. "I don't care twopence-halfpenny whether she is or is not a lady. I only know she is the most sensible and practical woman I ever met. In the first place, she has the faculty—so rare among women—of carrying out orders to the very letter: in the second place, she has a clear, shrewd brain, unhampered by any hard-and-fast theories; thirdly, and most important item of all, she has so much common sense that it amounts to genius—positively to genius, sir.'" (**Catherine Louisa Pirkis, 'The Black Bag Left on a Doorstep', The Experiences of Loveday Brooke, Lady Detective**, 1893)

“I hope you understand what a great—a stupendous work it is?” he added, as he sank into a chair. “It is a work that will leave its impress upon thought in all the ages to come. Only a man who has studied comparative philology as I have for the past thirty years, could gauge the magnitude of the task I have set myself [...] the elemental sounds of speech that are common to all languages” [...] “you have not yet told me what sort of an elemental sound old Sandy made when he fell. If you’ll give me pen and ink, I’ll write down a full account of it all, and you can incorporate it afterwards in your treatise.” (Pirkis, ‘The Murder at Troyte’s Hill’, 1893)

--Jacques Lacan, Jacques Derrida, and ‘The Purloined Letter’ – cf. *The Purloined Poe*, ed. John P. Muller. Peter Barry’s *Beginning Theory* and Andrea Hurst’s chapter in *After Derrida* may help.

13. ‘at the base of the whodunit we find a duality, and it is this duality which will guide our description. The novel contains not one but two stories: the story of the crime and the story of the investigation [...] It is no accident that [the second story] is often told by a friend of the detective, who explicitly acknowledges that he is writing a book; the second story consists, in fact, in explaining how this very book came to be written [...] fable (story) [i.e., *fabula*] and subject (plot) [i.e., *syuzhet*] [...] the story is what happened in life, the plot is the way the author presents it to us’ (Todorov)

14. ‘the curious analytical reasoning from effects to causes’ (*Sign of Four*, Ch.1)

15. ‘You have attempted to tinge it with romanticism, which produces much the same effect as if you worked a love-story or an elopement into the fifth proposition of Euclid’ (*Sign of Four*, Ch.1)

16. ‘each likens [the voice] – not to the voice of an individual of any nation with whose language he is conversant – but the converse’ (‘*Rue Morgue*’)

17. ‘less visible, less visibly violent modes of “social control” [...]’

The form is based on the hypothesis that *everything might count*: every character might be the culprit, every action or speech might by belying its apparent banality or literalism by making surreptitious reference to an incriminating Truth [...] Detective fiction is thus always implicitly punning on the detective’s brilliant *super-vision* and the police *supervision* that it embodies. His intervention marks an explicit bringing-under-surveillance of the entire world of the narrative. As such, it can be alarming. When Poe’s Dupin reads his sidekick’s mind in “The Murders in the Rue Morgue” [...] when Sherlock Holmes deduces a man’s moral and economic history from his hat in “The Adventure of the Blue Carbuncle”—these prodigies are greeted as though they opened up the fearful prospect of an absolute surveillance under which everything would be known, incriminated, policed’ (DA Miller, Foreword & Ch.2, *The Novel and the Police*, 1988)

18. ‘Money is always the motive of crime in detective fiction, yet the genre is wholly silent about *production* [...] [the factory] is innocent, and thus free to carry on [...] Detective fiction is crowded with stereotypes. The difference between innocence and guilt returns as the opposition between stereotype and individual. Innocence is conformity; individuality, guilt. It is, in fact, something irreducibly personal that betrays the individual: traces, signs that only he could have left behind. The perfect crime – the nightmare of detective fiction – is the featureless, deindividualized crime that anyone could have committed [...] Detective fiction [...] exists expressly to dispel the doubt that guilt might be impersonal, and therefore collective and social [...] A guilty party: crime is always presented as an exception [...] Agatha Christie’s first book is set at the same time as the massacres of the Great War, yet the only murder of interest occurs on the second floor of Styles Court.’

‘...a signifier that always has several signifieds and thus produces *numerous* suspicions [...] This is also part of the criminal’s guilt: he has created a situation of semantic ambiguity, thus questioning the usual forms of human communication and human interaction. In this way, he has composed an audacious *poetic work* [...] Holmes takes in the only possible meaning of the various clues in a glance. [...] [The detective] will have to reinstate the univocal links between signifiers and signifieds’ (Moretti)

19. '[scholars & detectives] decode signs, decipher clues, and brood over intractable puzzles [...] I pursue the analogies between detection and critique as styles of suspicious reading that blend interpretation with moral judgment. And here the similarities proliferate at a dizzying rate: a penchant for interrogating and indicting, a conviction that deceit and deception are ubiquitous and that everyone has something to hide, a commitment to hunting down criminal agents and a reliance on the language of guilt and complicity. I've already noted that the practitioner of critique shares with the detective a professionally mandated mood: an ambient attitude of mistrust that expresses itself in a refusal to let down one's guard. Let us now link mood to morality in order to throw out a hypothesis: *like the detective, the critical reader is intent on tracking down a guilty party* [...] Like [JB] Priestley's protagonist, [critics] stomp their muddy boots through the drawing-rooms of culture while laying bare its complicity in a history of wrongdoing [...] what drives such manoeuvres is not just an allegiance to ethical or political values but also aesthetic criteria of adroitness, ingenuity, sophistication, intricacy, and elegance' (Rita Felski, 'An Inspector Calls', in *The Limits of Critique*, 2015)

Further Reading—

Any of the novels/short stories featuring women detectives listed in the studies below—there were many, so the best thing to do would be to browse & see what you find.

Tanya Agathocleous, *Urban Realism and the Cosmopolitan Imagination in the Nineteenth Century* (2011)

Maurizio Ascari, *A Counter-History of Crime Fiction* (2007).

Lawrence Frank, *Victorian Detective Fiction and the Nature of Evidence: The Scientific Investigations of Poe, Dickens, and Doyle* (2003).

Emelyne Godfrey, *Masculinity, Crime and Self-Defence in Victorian Literature* (2011).

Kevin Hayes (ed.), *Edgar Allan Poe in Context* (2013).

Simon Joyce, *Capital Offenses: Geographies of Class and Crime in Victorian London* (2003).

Gerald Kennedy and Liliane Weissberg (eds.), *Romancing the Shadow: Poe and Race* (2001).

Joseph Kestner, *Sherlock's Sisters: The British Female Detective, 1864-1913* (2003).

Joseph McLaughlin, *Writing the Urban Jungle: Reading Empire in London from Doyle to Eliot* (2000).

Elizabeth Miller, *Framed: The New Woman Criminal in British Culture at the Fin de Siècle* (2008).

Pablo Upamanyu Mukherjee, *Crime and Empire: The Colony in Nineteenth-Century Fictions of Crime* (2003).

Martin Priestman (ed.), *Cambridge Companion to Crime Fiction* (2003); *Detective Fiction and Literature* (1990).

Caroline Reitz, *Detecting the Nation: Fictions of Detection and the Imperial Venture* (2004)

Matthew Rubery, *The Novelty of Newspapers: Victorian Fiction After the Invention of the News* (2009).

Amy Gilman Srebnick, *The Mysterious Death of Mary Rogers: Sex and Culture in Nineteenth-Century New York* (1995).

Ronald Thomas, *Detective Fiction and the Rise of Forensic Science* (1999).